Chapter 4: Umar Shaikh Dies

1 Murrain is an antique term for various infectious diseases that affected cattle and sheep (Scott).

2 Murrain was frequently used word in the mediaeval era for “death”. It was never used to refer a specific disease. Rather it as used as an umbrella term for what are now recognized as several different diseases. The list includes rinderpest, erysipelas, foot-and-mouth disease, anthrax, and streptococcus infections. The researchers suggest that it could also some of the diseases from the list could also affect the humans. Whenever such disease turned into epidemic, the term murrain came into play. The records speak about major sheep and cattle murrains in Europe during the fourteenth century. It combined with the Little Ice Age, resulting in the Great Famine of AD 1315-1317. It had left population of Europe thinned badly just before the onset of another calamity of the Black Death in AD 1348.

We also have references of Murrain in Biblical translations relating to the fifth plague brought upon Egypt. The book of Exodus (9:3) says: ‘Behold, the hand of the LORD is upon thy cattle which is in the field, upon the horses, upon the asses, upon the camels, upon the oxen, and upon the sheep: there shall be a very grievous murrain.’

‘Pestilence’ mentioned forty-seven times in forty-six verses of the Bible, is translated as ‘murrain’ by Christian apologists. One may check Psalms 91:3 KJV for confirmation.

A lot of superstitious stories too talk of the term. In few parts of Scotland, it was believed that force-fire cured it. In the current time, Murrain is used as a term for curse upon land and livestock, in various remote parts of Cumbria, England, and the Isle of Man. We also have a theory that during the medieval era the term became synonymous with witchcraft by a process of syncretism. A television show was inspired by this idea in AD 1975. The play was telecasted on ATV and was written by Manxman Nigel Kneal on 27 July of AD 1975. This was a part of the channel’s Against the Crowd drama strand.

We have a famous work of Gustave Doré called ‘The Murrain of Beasts’ (or ‘The Fifth Plague: Livestock Disease’), that appeared as one of his many illustrations for La Grande Bible de Tours AD 1866.

3 Kasan is an ancient town of Uzbekistan also known as Kosonsoy (Uzbek pronunciation) and Kasansay (Russian). It was called Kathan in ancient times.